

Implications of Intellectual Humility and Post-Transgression Response on Apology Quality

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Abstract

Apologies are vital for conflict resolution, and previous research has made clear that intellectual humility levels in the transgressor can produce higher quality apologies. Our research aims to build on this finding by identifying how the victim's post-transgressional response can influence apology quality in individuals with heightened intellectual humility. In the current experiment (N=108) participants in the experimental group first had their intellectual humility temporarily increased by explaining what intellectual humility was and asking participants to reflect on a time they acted with it. Then, participants read a scenario where they were the transgressor in a situation, and their actions negatively affected the victim. The victim then either gave a forgiving post-transgressional response, or a non-forgiving post-transgressional response. Our results found participants in the intellectual humility group did not report higher quality apologies compared to participants in the control condition. Apologies from participants who did receive a forgiving post-transgressional response did not significantly differ from participants who did not receive a forgiving response and there was not a statistically significant interaction between intellectual humility and post-transgressional response on apology quality. However, there was a positive correlation between the intellectual humility group and apology quality, reflecting previous research. The implications of our findings strengthen the argument that there is reason to further study the relationship between intellectual humility and apology quality. Additionally, it demonstrates that there is a less significant relationship between post-transgressional response and apology quality than previously thought.

Keywords: intellectual humility, apology, post-transgression response, forgiveness, conflict resolution